

Nutrition & Hydration Policy

SECTIONS 1–4: PURPOSE, SCOPE, RESPONSIBILITIES & MEAL PROVISION

1 PURPOSE

To ensure that all residents receive safe, nutritious, and adequate food and fluids that promote their health, wellbeing, and dignity, in accordance with HIQA National Standards and HSE guidelines.

2 SCOPE

- ✓ All staff involved in planning, preparing, delivering, and monitoring nutrition and hydration
- ✓ Meal planning, food safety, nutritional intake monitoring, fluid balance assessment
- ✓ Special dietary needs including allergies, religious/cultural preferences, and medically indicated diets

3 RESPONSIBILITIES

- ✓ **Provider & PIC:** Ensure adequate resources, training, and monitoring systems
- ✓ **Care Staff:** Support residents during meals, observe intake, record food/fluid charts, report concerns
- ✓ **Catering Staff:** Prepare meals per dietary plans; ensure food safety and hygiene
- ✓ **Healthcare Professionals:** Assess individual needs, provide care plans, oversee clinical nutrition
- ✓ **All Staff:** Promote dignity and choice; respect cultural/religious preferences; follow hygiene protocols

4 MEAL PROVISION

- ✓ Three main meals per day with optional snacks and drinks between meals
- ✓ Variety of choices respecting cultural, religious, medical, and personal preferences
- ✓ Menus planned with residents, dietitians, and relevant professionals
- ✓ Texture-modified diets provided as per assessment (soft, pureed)
- ✓ Mealtimes treated as social, dignified occasions with respectful staff support



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SECTIONS 5-7: RESIDENT INVOLVEMENT, SPECIAL DIETS & HYDRATION

5 RESIDENT INVOLVEMENT

- ✓ Residents encouraged to participate in menu planning and give feedback on meal quality
- ✓ Food preference forms completed on admission and reviewed regularly
- ✓ Special occasions, cultural celebrations, and milestones acknowledged in meal offerings
- ✓ Residents may assist in meal preparation or table setting to enhance independence
- ✓ Concerns raised through forums or keyworker discussions; feedback reviewed by management

6 SPECIAL DIETS

- ✓ **Medically prescribed:** Diabetic, low sodium, gluten-free
- ✓ **Texture-modified:** Pureed, minced and moist, soft
- ✓ **Cultural/religious:** Halal, kosher, vegetarian
- ✓ **Allergy/intolerance:** Lactose intolerance, nut-free
- ✓ Dietary needs documented in care plans; staff trained on allergy awareness and food handling
- ✓ Kitchen staff involved in understanding and preparing special meals

7 HYDRATION MANAGEMENT

- ✓ Access to clean, palatable drinking water at all times
- ✓ Regular fluid intake encouraged through daily routines and during meals
- ✓ Variety of drinks offered: water, juice, milk, warm beverages
- ✓ Fluid intake monitored for residents at risk of dehydration; fluid balance charts used when clinically indicated
- ✓ Staff trained in recognising signs of dehydration and responding appropriately

Nutrition & Hydration Policy

SECTIONS 8-10: FOOD SAFETY, MONITORING & REVIEW

8 FOOD SAFETY

- ✓ Adhering to HSE and HACCP (Hazard Analysis and Critical Control Points) guidelines
- ✓ All staff involved in food preparation complete certified food hygiene training
- ✓ Kitchen cleanliness, proper food storage, and correct handling procedures maintained
- ✓ Food temperatures monitored during preparation, storage, and serving
- ✓ Regular inspections of food preparation areas
- ✓ Immediate action for food-related incidents including suspected contamination or food poisoning

9 MONITORING & REVIEW

- ✓ Regular audits of meal quality, dietary records, and fluid balance documentation
- ✓ Feedback from residents, families, and staff on meal satisfaction
- ✓ Incident reporting of any food-related issues or near misses
- ✓ Review of compliance with dietary plans and special needs
- ✓ Ongoing staff competency checks and refresher training

10 POLICY REVIEW

- ✓ Reviewed annually by management or sooner if required
- ✓ Incorporates audit findings, staff/resident feedback, regulatory updates
- ✓ Considers incident and complaint trends related to food, fluid, or mealtime practices
- ✓ Reviewed policy approved by Registered Provider and communicated to all staff
- ✓ Superseded versions archived per record management procedures